

# Commas

COMMAS ARE USED TO SEPARATE ELEMENTS IN A SENTENCE.

Commas clarify information by separating words, phrases, or clauses. They are used to organize information into groups, sorting it so a sentence is understood correctly.



## SEE ALSO

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## Introductions

Sometimes, a sentence begins with a clause, phrase, or word that sets the scene and leads the way to where the main action begins in the second half of the sentence. A comma is placed after the introduction to make the reader pause and anticipate the main information. An introduction to a sentence could be a word such as *However*, a phrase such as *Three years ago* or a clause such as *If this happens*.

This is an introductory phrase.

Once upon a time, there was a garden.

A comma is placed after the introductory phrase, before the main information is revealed.

The main information follows the comma.

This is an introductory clause.

When Lisa visited the garden, she saw a flower.

A comma is placed after the introductory clause.

The main information comes after the comma.

## Working in pairs

If a sentence is interrupted by an additional phrase that is not essential to the understanding of the sentence, a comma is placed on either side of the phrase, like two parentheses. Without the commas, the information is treated as essential.

Sometimes, the interruption is placed at the beginning or end of a sentence. In these cases, only one comma is used, since a comma is never placed at the start or end of a sentence.

A flower, like a sock, can be striped.

The interruption is placed within a pair of commas to separate nonessential information.



A flower like a sock can be striped.

Without the commas, the information becomes part of the main sentence and changes its meaning.



A flower can be striped, like a sock.

A comma is placed before an interruption at the end of a sentence.

A comma is placed after an interruption at the start of a sentence.

Like a sock, a flower can be striped.